

Rising from Apprentice to Managing Director

– My journey of growth and leadership

Phil De Jager



© Phil de Jager 2025 South Africa.

Publisher: www.sakurabookpublishing.com

alta@sakurabookpublishing.com

Cover design: Alta H Haffner

ISBN:

(print)

(e-book)

All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or any means, including photocopying, recordings, or other electronic or mechanical methods without the prior written permission of the author and publisher, except in the case of brief quotations embodied in critical reviews and certain noncommercial uses permitted by copyright law.

CONTENTS

<i>About Phil de Jager</i>	<i>4</i>
<i>Foreword</i>	<i>5</i>
<i>Early homelife and formative years</i>	<i>7</i>
<i>Study commencement</i>	<i>9</i>
<i>Early career / sport</i>	<i>11</i>
<i>Career Continuation</i>	<i>17</i>
<i>Overseas Exposure</i>	<i>27</i>
<i>Management style</i>	<i>32</i>
<i>Sporting career</i>	<i>42</i>
<i>Industries I have worked in</i>	<i>48</i>
<i>Business Learnings / Life Challenges</i>	<i>50</i>
<i>Good Business Quotes</i>	<i>62</i>
<i>Key focus areas and life learnings</i>	<i>64</i>
<i>Conclusion / Summary</i>	<i>78</i>
<i>Testimonials</i>	<i>81</i>

About Phil de Jager



Phil De Jager is an accomplished business leader with over five decades of experience across the engineering, pharmaceutical, food, and manufacturing industries. From his humble beginnings as an apprentice to becoming a Managing Director. Phil has led major business turnarounds, international expansions, and strategic transformations. His passion for leadership, resilience, and people development is at the heart of his memoir, offering a compelling journey of growth and inspiration.

Foreword

This book attempts to convince young and older people that anything is possible if you **believe in yourself**. Don't be swayed by where you come from, your poor childhood, your background, or anything that would deter progress or success. It is amazing what can be achieved via a positive mindset and focus.

Decide what you would like to achieve early in life, so to be clear on possible goals for your life. Based on the benefits of social media platforms, research on poor or good careers and Companies to work for is easily accessible. So do some homework to make the best possible decision early in life. I was just told what to do and did it with some regrets later, but that did not deter me from changing my career. Remember it is your career, and you must take charge of your life **while listening and acting on the best advice**.

The decisions you make could have long-lasting value. In my case, where I just completed a very successful contract at a big company at the age of 73 and I can't wait to start the next project. I had many challenges, i.e. Friends distractions. Fortunately, I resisted peer pressure and focused on my studies and career.

**Nothing is impossible, the word
itself says I'M POSSIBLE.
~ Aubrey Hepburn**

I had a solid work ethic. A lesson I learned early in life was to be consistent on a daily basis. Consistency leads to great success.

I was always curious and willing to learn. I focused on improving my skills continuously.

“The difference between the impossible and the possible lies in a man's determination.” Tommy Lasorda

Early homelife and formative years

My Dad was a miner, I was his youngest son and child of five siblings. It was the culture of the day that the sons should follow in their dad's footsteps and also work on the mine which my brother and I did. My older brother became an apprentice Boiler maker and after 5 years, passed his trade test whereafter he became a qualified Artisan. I was encouraged by his degree of success and stability and achievement. At the age of 16, I decided to leave school, and like my brother, I became an apprentice Boilermaker. It was possible at the age of 16 to do an apprenticeship.

I had a poor upbringing as Miners did not earn much money and we stayed in semi-detached mine houses. We also moved from house to house in the same town. My mother and father were remarkably simple down-to-earth people with very little excitement in their lives. I respected them and loved them dearly. It was mostly work and sleep every day. As the youngest by 7 years, my siblings all left home and got married whilst I was a young boy living with my Parents. My Mother was a very industrious stay-at-home parent and my dad spent most of his life underground as a miner.

My dad was a devoted Christian. We went to church every Sunday, which stood me in good stead until today, which my wife and I conveyed to all our children. My dad was more outgoing, but my mother was a shy introvert. However, with an incredibly low income, it was amazing how they gave us a normal upbringing. This situation motivated me to be more successful and not to struggle like my parents. They were extremely trustworthy people.

As mentioned, I started working at the Sub Nigel gold Mine as an apprentice Boilermaker at the age of sixteen. (Still a young boy). However, this proved to be a good thing later in my life as I realised quickly that I was not going to remain a Boilermaker and work like this for the rest of my life.

I soon decided that I was unique and did not have to follow in my dad's footsteps of work in those terrible conditions, crawling around like a dog underground whilst inhaling dangerous dust, which killed him far too early.

Fortunately, I excelled in all forms of sport as a young boy, which allowed me to become a top athlete later. The discipline required to be a top athlete also helped in my working career and studies later.

You become what you study.
-Robert T. Kiyosaki

Study commencement

It is important to study to make progress in life, and it is beneficial for young people to recognize the value of dedicating some time to their education. Remember studying is a once-off event for a “fairly” brief time, but the benefits are **lifelong**.

“Although I enjoyed my job as a Boilermaker and the hand skills it gave me, I had bigger ambitions.”

Witnessing the tough life of my parents motivated me to start my Engineering studies with the assistance of Mine management whilst serving my apprenticeship. I made particularly substantial progress and passed every term. I worked as hard as I could to show that I was not just a good Boilermaker, but also a good student.

I realised earlier that to be successful; I had to study as hard as I could. Fortunately, I had a mother who pushed me, waking me early in the morning, to succeed in my studies. The studies went so well that by the age of nineteen, I reached the highest level of my engineering grades. I qualified after only 3 years to take my trade test, which I did and passed with excellence, which confirmed that I was a top-class Boilermaker. Soon after qualifying as a Boilermaker Artisan (age 19), I obtained my Mechanical Engineering Diploma.

I was the youngest artisan on the mine to obtain a diploma at the age of twenty as a qualified artisan. I was also the 1st Boilermaker to obtain a diploma in engineering. My dad was called from underground one morning to attend my diploma ceremony presented by the mine management. You can imagine how proud he was of his son standing there, being a miner and being honoured. It was a day that I will never forget. I then knew that I was unique and destined for bigger things than being a Boilermaker for the rest of my life. It is a lesson that young people should learn. You must believe that you are unique and can achieve remarkable things with the help of our Heavenly Father.

In later years, I completed a diploma in company direction and passed all final-year subjects of an International MBA. I also did an intensive MBA short course at the University of Cape Town – UCT. I need to mention that my future wife assisted me throughout my studies and encouraged me tremendously.

Early career / Sport

The engineer's diploma changed my life, and the mine management transferred me to another mine (Libanon Gold Mine) to become an Engineer in Training, which was incredibly good practical experience and exposure. At the age of 22 (1973), I married my girlfriend Antonette, and we stayed on the mine property. Over the next 4 years, we had two girls and a boy whilst I completed my Engineer-in-Training period. This training assisted me in applying for and obtaining a good engineering job at the chemical giant AECl in Sasolburg, which was successful. Another reason for me leaving mining was the fact that my dad died from a lung disease after all the time underground in the mine.

The time at the chemical company was an incredible experience for a young engineer as the plant operated 24 / 7 every week, it brought severe pressure to my personal life due to the time spent at work. However, it was a wonderful experience and great exposure. I was one of fifteen engineers at AECl. I was appointed manager of the VCM plant.

After 3 years, I was given the job of supervising the repair of one of our leaking reactors in Germany. This was a wonderful experience

as I was fortunate to attend the initial meetings with senior engineers of AECI to agree on the required specifications for this reactor repair. We then went to Germany to agree on the procedure with the Germans in Dusseldorf and Munich. I stayed behind in Germany for the next few months to execute this repair at a selected German Company.

The pressure was severe as AECI was losing big money every day with the reactor out of service. With this knowledge, I convinced the Germans to work night shift on this job. The job was done 30 days early, saving R30 million, back in the eighties. I contacted AECI South Africa with this good news, which I kept a secret until it was completed. You can imagine the welcome I had when I returned to South Africa earlier than expected. The company surprised me with a big welcoming party.

After that successful outcome, additional responsibilities came my way, and I was appointed as technical manager of the cyanide and peroxide plants of AECI and the VCM plant. I managed to sort out the serious issues that caused lots of downtime on the cyanide plant, as it was a **strategic site** due to supplying cyanide to the gold mines in the process of gold extraction. My corrective action increased output by 50%, which allowed an adequate supply of cyanide to the gold mines. The experience at AECI was priceless. After completing several cost-reduction projects, I recognised my strong analytical skills.

One Sunday, I happened to scroll through the job section of our local Sunday newspaper and came across a job vacancy for a Company Engineer in the largest pharmaceutical company in South Africa – Adcock Ingram. I was incredibly happy at AECl but decided (as a joke) to apply for this Job. It was a major shock to me when I got the call for an interview at Adcock Ingram. I decided to go for the interview more out of curiosity, as you can imagine, I could not leave AECl, especially after the recent German project and promotion.

However, I went for the interview and was surprised at how well it went, especially due to my AECl experience, which counted in my favor. I did not realise that AECl was recognised as such an important benchmark in business. I was driving in my car, back to my office just after the interview, when I received a call from Adcock Ingram and they offered me the Job. I got such a fright that I declined the Job and returned to AECl. Back in my office, I received another call, this time with an offer that I knew I could not decline.

I then communicated to the AECl executive that I was resigning, which was a big shock to them in light of my recent successful trip to Germany. They tried everything possible to retain my services, but I made up my mind. I was then working for AECl for a

period of 5 Years. Also, at Adcock Ingram Pharmaceuticals, I would be the only Company Engineer.

During this period, my mother died a year after my father at an early age of 54, compared to my father, who died at 63 years. She could not live without him.

During my time pursuing new careers, my lovely wife had the tough task of raising our 3 kids. Another boy was born 7 years after our youngest child. We were blessed, we had a Family of 2 boys and 2 girls in our twenties and enjoying a successful career.

In the end, I had a very successful career of 14 years at Adcock Ingram. I was extremely fortunate to have been allowed to rebuild/design a new layout for the packing plant. The company then sent me to Germany to be trained on the latest sterile equipment that we purchased for our sterile division. I came back and trained all the technical staff.

I went to Boston in the USA where I was trained on a reverse osmosis plant that we purchased to improve the water quality in our sterile division. After a phenomenally successful period at the pharmaceutical plant, I was promoted to Technical Director and given responsibility for the Consumer division as well. The total supply chain was added to my new role, i.e., Distribution, Production, Procurement, etc.

My MD called me in and sent me to Scotland to investigate the possibility of installing the Jeyes Blue line in South Africa, as we were importing the product. I installed this new Plant in South Africa the following year, which enabled us to produce the product at a much lower price locally.

The continuous development and innovation were enormous at Adcock Ingram, as I witnessed continuous new product launches. The manufacturing discipline that was required in a pharmaceutical factory required good manufacturing disciplines as we were producing products that could kill people, hence proper validations and good housekeeping were paramount. I learned to apply the Japanese culture of “full proof”, No mistakes called “**Poka-Yoke**”, as mistakes are not allowed in the pharmaceutical process. This focus will assist you in your future career, as mistakes in business can be costly.

Between career challenges, I developed into a top tennis player, winning numerous tournaments. I also became a 3 handicap golfer, playing tournaments all over South Africa. At a later age, I also became the Alberton Tennis and Squash Champion in one year, which was an outstanding achievement at the age of 36. Focusing on 3 types of sports was not easy, and today I regret the hours I spent away from my wife and children playing sports.

**Motivation gets you going, but
discipline keeps you growing.
-John C. Maxwell**

I must apologise to my wife and children today for being absent. I would advise young people to focus on fewer sports to restore and maintain a good family life balance while being married. During my first trip to Germany, I started coaching the factory staff for 2 months as I was the Vaal Triangle Tennis Champion in South Africa.

There were hours of hard work and discipline to achieve these sporting results. However, the discipline required to train hard was also evident in my success at work. I was also fortunate to work for incredibly good bosses who were also my mentors and assisted in my early development.

**Discipline is doing what needs
to be done, even if you don't
want to do it.**

Career Continuation

In the meantime, my Career / Business life progressed extremely well. I was always very goal-driven to achieve the best, which stood me in good stead as superior results meant good salary increases. I think that the competitiveness in sports assisted me tremendously to also be competitive in my job and always strive for the best, i.e., meeting agreed KPI's.

I hope young people take this lesson to heart that you must believe in your uniqueness and know that, with faith in our Heavenly Father, you can achieve great things.

These experiences over 14 years set me up for future career developments, as South African executives were aware of my success at Adcock Ingram and AECL.

The boss at Adcock Ingram was a great mentor to me, not just teaching me technical skills, but also trusting me in giving me more and more opportunities locally and abroad.

I was, however, surprised to be contacted and headhunted by the Chairman of a big export group who offered me the position of Managing Director in Port Elizabeth, South Africa, after 14 years

with Adcock Ingram and no plans to change companies. He made it clear to me that, based on my success at Adcock Ingram, he was making me an offer. I was then 42 Years old. Again, I had my doubts about leaving Adcock Ingram as I was extremely happy in the company, but the offer was of such a nature that I had to accept it. This took me to the ultimate position of **Managing Director** in a large group, which is logical based on my career achievements at that stage.

I felt immensely proud as I realised that I had progressed from the young apprentice boilermaker to Managing Director.

Unfortunately, we had to leave 2 Children behind in JHB to move to Port Elizabeth, a decision that we regretted later. The move to Port Elizabeth was also traumatic, hence away from the Family in Gauteng.

The new job was incredibly challenging as it involved total exports to Italy, France, Japan, Malaysia, and Europe. The Managing Director in this business makes all the key decisions on quality, procurement and selling prices. He also oversaw key negotiations with key suppliers in South Africa and overseas. Everything I know about negotiations I learned at this company is that I had to negotiate all over the world. I was away from home frequently, but fortunately, my wife was able to join me on occasional trips.

The 5 years with the group were good learning as I had the total management team reporting to me, hence good financial and global market experience. Purchasing was especially important as we had to buy all our raw materials from the local farmers, which were the "Dorper" sheep skins. The leather fairs were held in Paris, France, twice a year. Once finally tanned in Europe, these skins were sold as top-quality Leather garments across the world. The company was unfortunately sold to the larger opposition after 5 years, and we got offered good severance packages, which I accepted.

This meant that we had to return to Gauteng to a happy Family. The biggest Food Company in South Africa, Tiger Brands, recruited me to manage their edible oil business, SA Oil Mills in Randfontein in Gauteng. The company was owned 50/50 by Tiger Brands and Senwes, a Farmers co-op. Tiger Brands wanted to exit commodity businesses, hence joined forces with Senwes, to transform the business back to profitability to maximise the selling price. The key objective was my responsibility, and I had to prepare a "blue Paper" for this business transformation. Two weeks later, I submitted my findings/ proposals, which the company, Senwes, accepted immediately and became the holding Company as they purchased Tiger Brands 50%. The proposal included a Capex of 10 million rand to enable automation of the packing operation, which was very labor-intensive and was approved. In summary, Tiger Brands and

Senwes' edible oil plants were operating separately, hence total duplication of operations, i.e., a crushing (Crude oil) plant at Senwes and Tiger Brands, Refineries at Senwes and Tiger and separate oil packing operations. This situation led me to make a simple proposal to rationalise all operations, i.e. One Crude oil plant at Senwes and one refinery at Tiger Brands, with one new automated packing operation at Tiger Brands. This meant serious staff reduction, and we had to follow an ethical retrenchment process.

I had the privilege to manage this total process, which achieved all the goals in my blueprint. I have met the cost reduction target, and the Indian consortium Continental Oils bought the company from Senwes.. I chose not to work for the new Company due to a different culture. However, Senwes afforded me a good package for my efforts. This was the start of my Business Transformation focus up until today. My overseas exposure blessed me with the ability to see the big picture. Today, I can walk into any business and my analysis will indicate major improvements and cost savings.

Based on the great export exposure with my previous company I was recruited back to Adcock Ingram to become Director of Exports into Africa, Europe and the Far East. I was part of a small team with export sales not significant. My knowledge of the Adcock Ingram

products made this a logical move. I then persuaded the Tiger Brands management to put all products into one basket inclusive of Adcock Ingram who at that stage was part of Tiger Brands. My total export basket then consisted of pharmaceuticals, food products, and Beacon Sweets confectionary products. Three years later we grew into a much larger export company based on focus on one export company. Again, I enjoyed the exposure and I was also selling Tiger Brands products, the biggest food company in South Africa. Confectionary was a big part of them. It gave me a massive range of products to sell over the next few years with many overseas trips.

I travelled extensively to Africa, Europe and the Far East. I also sold products in Cyprus Greece very successfully. Unfortunately, the local market grew at such a pace that the local factories were unable to supply our export sales consistently, which throttled the export business. It was obvious that local companies received preference. The markets that I established died as we could not supply products to our customers until the RSA factories increased their capacities which would take too long.

I decided to leave the export business for this reason and started using my expertise in transforming companies and I Joined a company called Retailer Brands to do this. After transforming this company, I was asked to join a confectionary group in East London

South Africa called Candy Tops to transform them. I joined them as Technical Director. This was one of the very few negative moves in my career, as I realized that the candy product margins were extremely small, and we had to be very smart to make a profit. However, this gave me great confectionary exposure and the exposure to work for a loss-making company for the 1st time which I would need in my future career.

Candy Tops merged with their sister Company Mr. Sweet; hence it closed the East London operations and some products were transferred to Mr. Sweet in JHB. I was offered a package which I accepted. However, my confectionary experience stood me in good stead as I was contacted again by Tiger Brands in South Africa. Their confectionary businesses had serious problems after a failed project installation with a cost of R 200 million, and they recruited me on a contract basis to rectify the problems and restore the factory performance. They could not get the main gums & jellies line called a mogul to operate at the desired efficiency.

I installed a real-time production monitoring system to measure the performance 24/7. It took me 6 months to restore this line successfully. I was recruited for a period of 6 months but stayed for a period of 4 Years and was promoted to head up the supply chain at the confectionery business after all the success. This was an

intensive study in which I applied Pareto technology to identify the 20% that caused 80% of the problems. I not only rectified their problems but also improved productivity in all the confectionary plants in the gums & jellies division. I am very proud to say that it was a very successful contract period with great results and my relationship with this group continued at a later stage.

At that stage the Tiger Brands executive who recruited me to Tiger Brands became the Supply Chain Director of a beverage company called BEVCO in Johannesburg and at the end of my contract he asked me to come and assist him with this beverage company. Again, I immediately got involved in transforming the company and made improvements as the beverage business is also very competitive, hence cost savings via improved productivity improvements were critical. I spent a few years under contract with this company and achieved all my goals.

I was then contacted by Tiger Brands to become the Supply Chain Director for a contract period. I was given the responsibility of all confectionary plants including gums & jellies, candy and chocolate plants. This job had big responsibilities with a workforce of 1400 wages and 40 management staff reporting to me. I did not have to worry too much about the gums & jellies plant as I transformed it during my time there as I described earlier.

My focus shifted to the candy and chocolate operations with chocolate being the important one from a profitability point of view.

I had an unbelievable 14 Months, transforming these plants successfully and I was awarded a full bonus at the end of my stay. Productivity was improved, food safety standards were met and improved, and we retained all required quality certifications. Housekeeping was upgraded and it was like walking through a good hospital. The people were collaborating extremely well as they enjoyed my management style of “Trust and Inspire” not “Command and Control.” A highlight in my career was the staff jumping up and down and celebrating my return. It was incredible.

I also installed a Real-time production monitoring system “to measure OEE’s - Overall Equipment Efficiency. At the end of this contract, Tiger Brands asked me to transform their Black Cat peanut butter plant. This was a very interesting assignment as I managed to not only transform the business like the other ones, but they had a product processing problem linked to the quality of raw materials that I sorted out and the output from this plant increased tremendously. All standards as implemented at Tiger Brands plants were implemented in the Peanut Butter plant. Another very successful contract period and full bonus paid.

Just note all this work was done as a contractor as I have now been working 8 years after my retirement age (65) and I am now 73 years old. I learned the importance of “word of mouth” contacts The lesson is that you are never too old to be successful if you produce quality work.

I was then headhunted by a Company in the Powder cereal business called Future Life. This is a company that has been growing by 10 to 20 % per annum in the last ten years. They had to move from the old premises that became too small to a new site in Durban. They then required new expertise to assist with the “new” business. Their old site did not comply with food safety standards and many standards were lacking.

I relished the new 17 Months contract which allowed me to exercise my full experience within this business. I just had the most successful contract period with the business and the results improved tremendously with massive bottom-line savings and profitability improvement. I also installed a real-time production monitoring system which simplifies the operation tremendously.

Production capacity was identified as a major problem as the plant worked 6 days a week. I installed a new high-speed packing line which now allowed us to only work 4 days a week, hence major labor savings. Our food safety standards were upgraded and productivity improved. I just completed my contract at the end of March.

Who knows what is next! I am establishing my own ***Business Transformation Company*** via LinkedIn to reach many influential leaders who can contact me for business transformation projects. I also have superb testimonies that will stand me in good stead.

It should be mentioned that I was responsible for industrial relations with all these companies, making great experience in the annual wage negotiations.

Another important issue is the one of relationship building as in your future career, you might have to lean on some of these relationships forged early in your career.

I also made sure that I finished off on a high note at every company I worked for as you could one day need them again. You also leave a good legacy with each company.

Overseas exposure

I was very fortunate to travel abroad many times for business related issues.

During my early career with AECl, I was sent to Germany to fix one of the main reactors for a few months. It was great to experience new technology in Germany, hence expanding my engineering mindset and knowledge.

Adcock Ingram then sent me to Boston in the USA to select and purchase a new Reverse Osmosis plant for our sterile division where we needed RO water. They also sent me to Germany to purchase new sterile machinery to upgrade our technology. At a later stage, I then trained all the technical staff before the new machines arrived.

Adcock Ingram sent me to The Jeyes operation in East Kilbride Scotland to copy their Plant in South Africa which I completed very successfully and produced a better plant than in Scotland.

As part of a business transformation at a company called Continental Oils I went to Italy to commission equipment that I bought for the company to reduce costs via a major labor productivity upgrade.

The project was so successful that the company changed from a loss to a profit situation.

My time as Managing Director of Kolosus Holdings took me on many overseas trips i.e. Korea, China, Malaysia, Italy, France etc.

Back at Adcock Ingram, I was appointed as Export Director for Africa and Asia. I conducted several trips to Africa and Asia and our export Sales improved by 200% year on year. I started a new business in Cyprus in Greece where I sold key Tiger Brands products.

I was also invited by a Korean Pharmaceutical company to assess their new Pharmaceutical Plant in Korea.

All these overseas trips were incredible as I could apply many of the learnings in our local market to the benefit of the Companies that I upgraded.

Today I am extremely grateful to my lovely wife of 51 years who had to look after the children during all my overseas trips and sporting activities. She had a lot to do with improving my discipline, persistence and dedication to being successful. Her constant prayers and unselfishness are something I can never appreciate enough. She had a lot to do with the disciplined upbringing of our children and constant relationship with God which is the most important thing to all of us. He made all things possible. I can strongly advise young management to get overseas exposure as it broadens your benchmark standards.



Phil & Antonette de Jager

Countries and Cities visited for Business and Holidays

- Germany – Munich, Dusseldorf and Krefeld
- USA – Boston
- France – Paris.
- Italy – Rome, Capri, Venice, Solofra, Napoli
- Holland - Amsterdam, Vollandam
- Scotland – East Killbride,
- England – Londen, Manchester
- Greece – Cyprus
- Zimbabwe - Harare
- Angola – Luanda
- Ghana – Acra
- China – Shanghai, Beijing
- Korea – Seoul
- Japan – Tokyo, Kobe
- Singapore.
- Taiwan
- Malaysia – Kuala Lumpur
- Thailand – Bangkok
- Mauritius
- Namibia / Botswana
- Mozambique
- Zanzibar

*A leader is best when people
barely know he exists. When
his work is done, his aim
fulfilled, they will say: we
did it ourselves.*

-Lao Tzu

Management style

“A leader is one who knows the way, goes the way, and shows the way.” - John C. Maxwell

I always believed that it was critical to have the correct/effective Management style. I do not believe in ***a Command-and-Control*** style which results in staff fearing their leaders and must constantly look over their shoulders for being micromanaged. I promote a style of ***Trust and Inspire*** which allows people to Innovate and use their full potential to the benefit of their companies without the fear of failure.

*Too many businesses suffer from poor results due to **poor management** styles. The CEO of Microsoft took over at an embattled Microsoft in 2014 and turned the business around from a market value of 300 BN USD to 2 trillion USD today.*

Poor management must be identified early in a company and be eliminated.

During my career, I have found most managers were trained in the technical side of their Jobs, but not in good management practices or they exit university without required management training. The ability to uplift their subordinates is lacking and to achieve results via the people.

Their staff is not being trained, hence not trusted to do a good job. It was very clear to me in my career, that when there were staff problems to find out who was managing the people and without exception ***poor management*** would be the reason.

People don't leave bad jobs... They leave because of bad bosses, and poor management, who don't appreciate their value.
-Marcus Buckingham

Today is your opportunity to build the tomorrow you want.
-Ken Poirot

The bottom line is, bad managers are bad for business, and they're even worse for their employees.
-Arnold Smeets

"Ghandi was saying that human beings only use a small percentage of what they are capable of and the secret lies in extracting people's capability via a Trust and Inspire management style."

Poor management is in most cases the key reason for business failure or poor performance. Any problem can be traced back to the quality of management and the lack of a good leader. Too many managers are just *managing* instead of *leading* people.

“The challenge of leadership is to be strong, but not rude; be kind, but not weak; be bold, but not a bully; be humble, but not timid; be proud, but not arrogant; have humor but without folly.” “The art of leadership is saying no, not saying yes. It is very easy to say yes.”

“The workforce demands a new kind of leader – a leader who can see develop and unleash the greatness in every person “

When I left the company Tiger Brands, one of the senior managers came to me and thanked me for ***giving them wings to fly***, based on my delegating style. That confirmed my success with utilizing people effectively while they develop.

Another important thing to have is “Passion”. I am 73 but have lost none of my passion. Where there is passion there is a belief that all things are possible.

People with the right attitude are critical, in some cases, it is better to appoint a person with the right attitude instead of better qualifications.

The other embarrassing observation during my career was the fact that the floor staff in a factory remains employed for many years i.e. 20 years, but management changes every 2 to 3 years. Every new manager or Executive arrives with “new Ideas” that disappear over a year or two and they are gone. Shopfloor staff questioned me many times about this, and it has become a laughing matter. Only a few Executives can motivate and uplift their staff and walk a long sustainable journey with them.

Many managers are also not in touch with the needs of their people, hence managing or leading people they don't know. They also don't invite ideas and inputs from the lower-level staff who do all the work at floor level whilst management sits in their Ivory Towers.

Emotional intelligence is critical when managing or leading people.

The importance of handling relationships correctly is very important.

” Being a leader is a privilege to have. Your job is about being able to help people to achieve their best potential.”

“People have greatness inside of them – so my job as a leader is to unleash their potential – not control the me”

“It is a privilege, not an entitlement, to lead”

“Vulnerability is not a weakness; it is our greatest measure of courage”

“People will forget what you have said, people will forget what you have done, but they will never forget how you made them feel”

**Emotional intelligence is your ability to recognise and understand emotions in yourself and others, and your ability to use this awareness to manage your behaviour and relationships.
-Travis Bradberry**

It is also good to identify mentors throughout your career. These must be trusted by high-integrity colleagues who can give you honest feedback on a regular basis, and vice versa. This network will stand you in good stead later in your career.

In my experience, many companies don't have clear strategies or goals for their business or departments. For example, no strategy to improve their Supply Chain. Companies complete their annual budgets without any strategic preparation like a "Bos Beraad" or "think tank" to agree on the next year's strategy. There might be structure changes based on the new strategy, but not foreseen in the budget.

Mission and Vision statements are also absent in many businesses. The one that I find intriguing is the comment or advertisement in Companies that "People are our most important assets" However when a business gets in financial difficulty people the "most important " assets are being dismissed first.?

Nobody in the management is investigating how to grow the business instead of closing it down.

Remember structure follows strategy. Many companies do not change their structure after changing their strategy, then implementation becomes a problem

There will also be times in your career when you will have to take risks i.e. making critical decision/s. You will gain experience from the outcome right or wrong.

“We take risks knowing that risks will sometimes result in failure, but without the possibility of failure, there is no possibility of success. “

Remember the book called “Failing Forward” The most successful people in the world failed many times, but they learned from it. It is not a shame to fail.

It is also important to embrace new technologies as the world is changing so rapidly today, i.e. AI technology.

Finally, the importance of good communication is critical. It is so important that the company strategy and goals are clear to the total workforce.

Effective communication in the workplace isn't just about speaking clearly, it's about ensuring your message is heard and understood.

-Sheryl Sandberg

In every thriving workplace, communication is the thread that weaves success.

-Anna Richards

**The art of communication is the
language of leadership.
-James Humes**

As you take on more responsibility in your career, you will have bigger teams reporting to you, hence the importance of having the right people under you. People that you can delegate to, and trust all your goals will be achieved. This is where the **Trust and Inspire** style is so important. All levels of staff should be empowered all the time.

It is also very important to celebrate success down to the shop floor. In many companies, the Management team might celebrate, but the shopfloor never benefits i.e. the people who do a lot of work.

I had a banner at the entrance of my company in Port Elizabeth where I was the Managing Director which read “**WORK SMART AND HAVE FUN**” and we applied it.

Sporting career

Sports played a major part in my life and even at 73 today I love watching sports and going to the Gym on a regular basis. Remember that none of this will be possible without good health, hence keeping a steady diet and regular training is critical. I showed great talent at school as I played Rugby, did well in athletics participated at a high level of Gymnastics where I earned a silver medal at a training camp. As a result, I became a very good trampolinist.

However, at a later stage in school, I got interested in Tennis via my sister and brother-in-law who played tennis. I did not realize that this would become my main sport in which I excelled and won about 20 Titles throughout my career. I also had success at the provincial level and won the prestigious Vaal Triangle championship for 4 years. During my AECL business trip to Germany, I had to coach the total company staff for 2 Months in Dusseldorf.

I had a tennis court at home and coached about 60 pupils every week. At one stage I coached all the Champions in their age groups i.e. under 12, 14, 16 and 18 years old. At that stage, I was playing 1st League tennis. My two best wins were beating the Free state no.1 player doing a provincial match and beating the

South African No.1 under 16 player called Pieter Aldrich who later won international tournaments and were in the top ten Men's double players in the world.

During this time, I also started playing Golf and became a 3-handicap player within 2 years. My best tournament score was 71. Gross score at the Macau vlei Golf course in Vereeniging where I won the competition. I was also fortunate to play on the world renowned Glen Eagles course in Scotland. The 2014 Ryder Cup was played on that course.

In my late 20's due to being a good tennis player I started playing squash and excelled rapidly as I enjoyed the speed of the game and the associated fitness.

At that stage, I was the Alberton tennis champion for a few years. One night after a game of squash the top players were discussing who was going to be the squash champion later that year. Very bravely I threw my hat in the mix with the prediction that I would win both the Tennis and Squash titles of Alberton Clubs in that year.

This prediction was a bit presumptuous as I was the no. 44 player on the ladder at the squash club. I am using this story to show you young people that if you put your mind to something (even the impossible) it can be achieved.

Without going into too much detail I started doing roadwork i.e. jogging and sprinting for the next few months before the Championships in September of 87. The Tennis championship was 1st and I won it comfortably as I was extremely fit training mainly for the Squash championship.

During that year I improved my position on the squash ladder from 44 to the top ten.

A few weeks later I was crowned the new Alberton squash Champion after the Tennis title and my wish came true. A lesson to many out there that you can achieve anything you put your mind to.

Some of my Saturdays consisted of squash from 6 to 7 am Saturday mornings, thereafter 18 holes of Golf from 8 am to 1 pm and then 1st league Tennis that afternoon.

However, this sports discipline as indicated stood me in good stead in my business career where I could apply the same discipline, dedication and competitiveness. I also think this has a lot to do with the fact that I am still managing big companies as a Transformation Specialist at the age of 73 and still achieving great results.

**What you do today can improve all your
tomorrows.**

-Ralph Marston

**Self-discipline starts with the mastery of
your thoughts. If you don't control what you
think, you can't control what you do.**

-Napoleon Hill

**Discipline is the bridge between
goals and accomplishments.**

-Jim Rohn

Unique Life moments

- The day I got married to my lovely wife Antonette
- The Days when each of children, grandchildren and great-grandchildren were born.
- Presented Mr. Mandela with a cheque for his 75th birthday celebrations in Port Elizabeth.
- Spent an evening with ex-Protea Captain Hansie Cronje as he was our speaker for the evening
- Spent a day on the Great Wall of China.

- I was taken through the Murray Field Scotland and their Rugby clubhouse and stood in the center of the field.
- Played 18 holes of Golf on the famous Ryder Cup Gleneagles Golf course in Scotland.
- Being taken to a Tennis tournament in a Pontiac Firebird by an American Family.
- Scoring a hole-in-one at the Vereeniging Country Club and winning a Golf competition with a score of 71 gross from an 8 handicap at Macau Vlei Golf Club.
- The day when my dad joined me in congratulations on passing my Trade test and was awarded an Engineering diploma by the Mine executive.
- Passing the MBA final year exam.
- Trips to Germany, Scotland, England, Italy, France, Holland, China, Japan, Korea, Boston USA, Malaysia, Taiwan, Singapore, Hong Kong, Bali, Phuket Thailand, Kenya, Zimbabwe, Zambia, Ghana, Botswana, Mozambique, Zanzibar, Cyprus. Many with my lovely wife.
- A Weekend visit to the Isle of Capri in Italy.
- Attended a Church service with my son Philip at Yonggi Cho church in South Korea.
- Spending time with my two sons in China / Korea.
- Attended the 1995 Rugby World Cup win at Ellispark with my Management team as MD

- Seeing my daughters and sons winning Tennis tournaments.
- The day I returned to Tiger Brands in Durban and saw the staff celebrating my return.
- The day when Lizel was saved during a serious car accident and Philip was hit by a car and Charlene survived a bomb scare whilst in a day clinic and also saved me from a serious incident at AECL.
- The day my youngest son Anton was chosen to play squash for South Africa and became a prefect at the High School.
- The day Anton's life was saved after a horrific car accident.
- The quality of my mother and my Wife's food-making ability.
- The day when I gave my heart to my lord Jesus, and he saved me.
- The weekly communications with my brother for more than 50 Years.
- I ran 5 km in 19 minutes and 30 seconds training for the squash championship.

Industries I have worked in

- My career path was extremely interesting as described.
- See below the list of different businesses from start to current :
- Gold Mines as Engineer in Training – JHB – 5 Years
- Chemical Plant – AECL as Engineer on projects – JHB – Engineer – 5 Years
- Pharmaceuticals/Consumer Products– Adcock Ingram laboratories – JHB – Technical Director – 14 Years
- Sunflower oil – SA Oil Mills – JHB – OPS Director – 4 Years
- Leather Production and total exports – Kolosus – Port Elizabeth – Managing Director – 4 Years
- Consumer Products exports – Adcock Ingram / Tiger Brands – Director Exports – 2 Years
- Consumable products (Soups) - Retailer Brands – JHB - OPS Director – 1 Year
- Confectionary products – Candy Tops – East London – OPS Director.- 4 Years
- Confectionary Products – Tiger Brands – Durban – Ops Director – 2 Years
- Beverage – BEVCO - JHB – Ops Director – 1 Year

- Confectionary (All Plants) – Tiger Brands – Durban – Ops Director.
- 1 year Tiger Brands Black Cat peanut butter plant – Randfontein
– JHB - Ops Director - 1 year
- Supply Chain head -Future life – Durban – Powder porridges
– **(Current)** – 17 Months
- You will notice that towards the end of my career, my duration at companies were short due to the contract periods appointed to do business transformation.

Business Learnings / Life Challenges:

- Do a proper investigation into the Company you would like to work for i.e. Workplace safety, People culture, location, Product types, Financial stability, Management style, Incentives, etc.
- Working for a loss-making company can be very negative as the general thinking is one of cost-cutting and not growth.
- The Company must add value to your career.
- When you leave a company remember the grass is not always greener on the other side, hence you must leave for good reasons and do your homework.
- Determine whether the Management style is “Command & Control” i.e. micromanagement or they have a “Thrust & Inspire” style.
- This can influence your progress in a Company as some Management styles will not allow you to innovate or develop.
- Determine whether companies do have development programs for you so that you grow in every Company where you work.
- Analyze your Company fully so that you understand the total business.
- In this way, you can add value to the business.

**Ability is what you're capable of doing.
Motivation determines what you do.
Attitude determines how well you do it.
-Lou Holtz**

- Identify companies that might allow you overseas exposure and experience.
- This exposure will stand you in good stead as your global mindset develops.
- Join companies that are stable, and where you can see your future development.
- Ensure that you grow your business knowledge/experience in every Company you work for.
- Surround yourselves with the “right” people to assist you. If you trust and inspire these people, your results will be excellent.

- Don't "carry" people that don't want to improve, (even after training) .
- The wrong person will take up a great percentage of your management time.
- Incentivize staff, if possible, to achieve urgent goals.
- The cost of doing things must always be self-funding.
- Decide whether you want to work for a big corporate company (maybe more security, but more controls and "red" tape) or for a smaller company where your inputs might be valued more, but possibly less security.
- Hire effective staff that can add value from day one, but also develop new staff to add value at a later stage.
- Learn to celebrate success, so that staff can see that the place they work for is not just working smart but are also having fun.
- Becoming a Managing Director is like entering a new world i.e. suddenly you have many more managers from various disciplines reporting to you for direction. This is where a Trust and Inspire style added tremendous value.
- I chose to trust the Managers under me as being the specialists in their jobs and I focused on the Trust and Inspired part of it.

- Maintaining your work-life balance is very important.
- Too many managers are taking work home.
- The reason for this is the possible lack of good planning or time management.
- Procrastination is a big sin with many people, they take too long to get things done.
- In the case of really too much work, work should be delegated to others to assist, but it is critical to spend quality time with your family.
- Management fails to realize that for a small financial cost, a lot of good work can be done.
- It's a relief to know that Anton recovered after such a difficult time and has gone on to build a successful career as a Senior IT programmer.

- There was another challenging time when the companies I worked for closed.
- The staff uncertainty was enormous and good and honest communication during this time was critical.
- The anxiety to get the next job was always worrying, but God supplied in every instance.
- I learned early in my career on project work to under promise and over delivery.
- If you say the project will take 6 Months and you do it in 7 months management frowns, however, if you said 8 Months, but took 7 Months (Same result) you are a hero.
- The saying that failing to plan leads to a failed plan is so true.
- The Western world doesn't plan long enough, and is slow with implementing, whereas the Japanese culture spends a long time planning but implementing quickly.

Celebrate Excellence:

"Recognising Contributions and Amplifying Success"

Recognising people's good work isn't just about praise—it's about reinforcing the behaviours and values that drive organisational excellence.

Celebrating results is how leaders show that effort, perseverance, and collaboration matter. When people feel seen, appreciated, and connected to a larger purpose, they become more engaged, more loyal, and more inspired to contribute at their best.

This principle is grounded in three key leadership beliefs:

Recognition fuels motivation.

- A simple "well done" can be more powerful than a bonus. It builds confidence and reinforces a sense of value and belonging.
- Celebration creates culture.
- Taking time to honour milestones—big or small—strengthens team cohesion and embeds a culture of achievement.
- Visible leadership sets the tone.
- When leaders actively notice and acknowledge excellence, it signals to everyone that high standards and accountability are non-negotiable.

Recognising the Invisible Win

– A Lesson from the Factory Floor

It was during my tenure at Adcock Ingram, right in the middle of a major supply chain overhaul, when I learned one of my most valuable leadership lessons—not from a boardroom, but from a boiler room.

We had been struggling with downtime in one of our critical production lines. A persistent maintenance issue had become a thorn in the side of our operations team, affecting output and morale. While the leadership team was consumed with strategic planning and broader turnaround goals, it was Sipho, a soft-spoken artisan fitter, who quietly took the initiative to diagnose the root cause.

He worked after hours, pouring over manuals and consulting retired colleagues. Within days, he proposed a small but elegant solution—a minor redesign to the sealing system that eliminated the fault. The line returned to full productivity. No fanfare. No formal recognition. Just results.

When I found out, I asked him to join the next management meeting—not to report, but to be recognised. I shared his story with the broader team, highlighting how his ownership, curiosity, and initiative embodied the culture we aspired to build. We gave him a framed certificate, but more importantly, we gave him a voice. He walked out of that meeting a different man—and I believe, a future leader was born that day.

That moment taught me this: Recognition isn't about ceremony—it's about dignity. And celebration isn't a distraction from work. It's what gives it meaning.

Not to be affected by peer pressure from friends or other people means

Developing the confidence and self-awareness to make decisions based on your own values, goals, and judgment—rather than simply following what others expect or demand of you. It involves staying true to who you are, even when those around you may be doing something different or trying to influence your choices.

This doesn't mean ignoring good advice or being stubborn. Rather, it's about critically evaluating suggestions and not compromising your integrity or direction just to fit in or gain approval. Peer pressure can come in subtle forms, such as the fear of missing out (FOMO), the desire to be liked, or the discomfort of going against the group. Resisting it requires inner strength, clarity about your own principles, and sometimes, the courage to stand alone.

By not being swayed by peer pressure, you maintain control over your own life. You set your own standards, choose your own path, and earn respect for being authentic and principled.

.

Leadership Insight:

The Strength to Stand Apart

One of the most critical lessons I've learned on my journey is the importance of not being swayed by peer pressure—whether from colleagues, friends, or even the broader industry. Leadership often requires standing firm in your convictions, especially when the easier path would be to go along with the crowd.

There were times in my career when popular opinion leaned in one direction, but my experience, instincts, and values pointed another way. In those moments, I had to decide whether to blend in or speak out. Choosing the latter was not always easy, but it was always right. True leadership isn't about popularity—it's about responsibility, integrity, and the courage to act in alignment with your principles.

Peer pressure doesn't end in schoolyards; it exists in boardrooms, team meetings, and social circles. But when you build a strong sense of self and a clear vision of what you stand for, you're better equipped to make decisions that reflect your true purpose—not someone else's expectations.

Use Your Time Effectively

– We Don't Have Time to Waste

Time is the one resource we all receive in equal measure—24 hours in a day. Yet, how we choose to use it determines the quality and impact of our lives. In leadership, in business, and in personal growth, time is often the hidden variable behind success and failure.

We often say, “There’s not enough time,” when in truth, time is constant; it’s our focus, priorities, and discipline that vary. The real challenge lies not in finding more hours, but in eliminating what doesn't serve our purpose.

The Cost of Wasted Time

Every hour wasted is an opportunity lost—an opportunity to learn, to lead, to build, to connect, or to rest and rejuvenate purposefully. Wasted time adds up. A few minutes of indecision here, an unproductive meeting there, and soon days, weeks, or even years drift by with little to show for it.

In leadership roles, this inefficiency is amplified. Your misuse of time not only affects your outcomes, but those of your team, your business, and sometimes even your industry.

Time Discipline as a Competitive Advantage

High performers share a common trait: they respect their time fiercely. They are intentional with their calendars. They delegate well, automate what can be, and prioritize high-impact activities. They understand that saying “yes” to the wrong things is saying “no” to what truly matters.

As a managing director or turnaround specialist, one of your first levers is time. Time audits, tighter agendas, focused deliverables—these changes may seem small, but they create momentum. You reclaim control not just of your schedule, but of your business trajectory.

Reflection from Experience

Throughout my journey from apprentice to managing director, I learned this lesson repeatedly. The moments I grew the most—whether launching a new product line, leading a turnaround, or mentoring a future leader—were rarely the result of chance. They came from focused effort, ruthless prioritization, and the decision to act, not wait. I've seen struggling operations transform not because we had more money or talent, but because we started using our time differently. We stopped debating endlessly. We stopped tolerating inefficiency. We got moving—quickly, intelligently, together.

Practical Wisdom

- Block time for what matters most—before the noise of the day takes over.
- Evaluate your week: What drained your energy? What moved the needle?
- Don't confuse activity with productivity. Movement isn't always progress.
- Learn to say no. Protect your time like you would your health or your money.
- Make decisions. Perfectionism is a time thief disguised as high standards.

This principle—***"use your time effectively"***—is not just advice; it's a mindset. It's a refusal to drift. It's a commitment to live and lead with urgency, clarity, and purpose. Because in the end, we don't manage time. We manage ourselves, within the time we have.

Leadership Reflection:

Use Your Time Effectively – We Don't Have Time to Waste

Time is the most democratic resource on earth—everyone gets 24 hours a day. But how we use those hours defines our results, our legacy, and our lives.

Early in my career, I learned a hard truth: **wasted time is never neutral—it compounds negatively.** It can cost you momentum, credibility, relationships, and opportunities that don't come around twice.

In leadership, time is not just a personal resource; it becomes a multiplier—or a bottleneck—for everyone who depends on you. When you use time effectively, your team moves faster, decisions are sharper, and results accelerate. When you don't, the ripple effect is damaging. Here's what I've learned:

- **Being busy is not the same as being productive.** Filling your calendar is easy; delivering real value takes focus.
- **Say no to the trivial many** so you can say yes to the vital few.
- **Decision delays are time thieves.** It's better to act with 80% clarity than to stagnate waiting for 100%.
- **Protect your time ruthlessly.** It is your most precious, non-renewable asset.

One of the first signs of a high-performing team or leader is time discipline. Meetings have a purpose. Priorities are clear. Energy goes where it matters most. I've seen organizations transform simply by shifting how they value and manage time.

If there's one takeaway from this chapter, let it be this: Don't drift. Don't delay. Don't waste time. Use it with intention—because we don't get to choose how much time we have, but we always get to choose how we use it.

Good Business Quotes

- ‘There is only one boss. The customer. And he can fire everybody in the company from the chairman on down, simply by spending his money somewhere else.’ – Sam Walton
- ‘If you’re trying to create a company, it’s like baking a cake. You have to have all the ingredients in the right proportion.’ – Elon Musk
- ‘Our work is the presentation of our capabilities.’ – Edward Gibbon
- ‘First-rate people hire first-rate people; second-rate people hire third-rate people.’ – Leo Rosten
- ‘If you listen to your fears, you will die never knowing what a great person you might have been.’ – Robert H. Schuller
- ‘If you don’t drive your business, you will be driven out of business.’ – B. C. Forbes
- ‘If you want to kill any idea in the world, get a committee working on it.’ – Charles Kettering.
- ‘Meetings are indispensable when you don’t want to do anything.’ – John Kenneth Galbraith

- Trust is the lubrication that makes it possible for organizations to work.’ – Warren Bennis Word of mouth is the best medium of all.’
– William Birnbach
- The work of the individual remains the spark that moves mankind ahead even more than teamwork.’ – Igor Sikorsky
- If you don’t understand the details of your business, you are going to fail.’ – Jeff Bezos

Key focus areas and life learnings

- Work hard whilst working smart having strong principles i.e. your word must be your word. People can always trust you.
- **Trust and Inspire** people to achieve the best. Through that, you will achieve more.
- Innovation will thrive.
- Be kind to people all the time.
- Be generous to people, because giving is better than receiving, but by giving you will reap abundantly.
- Don't be shy to show that you are a Christian and that all that you have achieved came from Jesus.
- Never fly solo, the Holy Spirit was sent to guide us, lead us and protect us.
- God's plans are always better than your plans.
- Have clear goals on what you want to achieve and apply consistent behavior to achieve them.
- Have discipline in your life.
- Focus on doing the best every day.
- Enjoy life to the fullest but in a responsible manner.
- Be a Leader to people, not a manager.

- Difficult times will come your way like with all of us, but believe that you can overcome anything with God's help.
- Remember that development in life comes from regular failures, but we learn from it and go forward stronger. (Read the book "Failing Forward")
- Have discipline in life to lead a healthy lifestyle relating to Food and Exercise.
- Don't let peer pressure influence you like with so many falling into that trap.
- Stick with your agreed principles and don't be swayed by negative behavior from your peers.
- Remind yourself regularly of where you find yourself in life. Are you living the life that you want to live?
- Your cost to a company should always be self-funding, hence my savings to the company exceed my cost.
- Always recognize people's good work and celebrate success.
- Don't procrastinate on doing things immediately.
- Don't worry about things you can't control.
- Don't compare yourself to other people. Don't waste your time.
- Manage your time effectively. We don't have the time to waste.

- Watch what you say. Your words carry incredible power.
- Discipline now, Freedom later. Discipline is critical.
- You must make your own happiness. Be content with yourself.
- While God is opening the next door, praise him in the hallway.
- Good communication is critical in all areas of your life.
- Control how you respond to people.
- Your habits and routines shape you.
- Never stop learning. Learn every day.
- Your integrity is non – negotiable.

Bible verses relatable to your career and Job situation

- “Commit your Plans to the Lord and your plans will succeed”
– Proverbs 16:3
- “I can do all things through him who gave strength”
– Philippians 4:13
- “It is well with the man who deals generously and lends who
conducts his affairs with justice” – Psalm 112:5
- “Trust the Lord with all your heart and lean not on your own
understanding”

AI importance

Many businesses have already implemented the use of AI technologies with great success. Many companies lag and will find competing with AI-competent companies difficult. The pace of AI development is so rapid that you will struggle to catch up to those who have implemented this technology. It was identified via a recent study that Company executive boards are not up to speed with AI technologies, but they are entrusted to manage the Company.

This is a big risk going forward for any Company, hence the required skills must be obtained rapidly.

Leading in the Age of AI

When I started my journey as an apprentice, the tools of management were simple: a pen, a calculator, a clipboard, and a sharp mind. Decisions were driven by personal experience, intuition, and long hours of discussion in boardrooms. Today, we are entering an era where artificial intelligence (AI) can analyze mountains of data in seconds, forecast demand, optimize supply chains, and even draft business strategies.

And yet, despite all this advancement, the essence of leadership has not changed, it still requires vision, integrity, empathy, and the ability to make sound decisions under uncertainty. What has changed is how we lead.

AI is not here to replace managers, it's here to augment them. The leaders who will thrive in this new era are those who can harness AI to enhance their decision-making, not outsource it. From customer analytics and operational efficiency to talent management and predictive forecasting, AI offers insights that were unimaginable just a decade ago.

During my time leading large-scale operations and managing complex turnarounds, I often relied on data to guide strategic shifts. But as technology advanced, I began to see how AI could do more than report on the past, it could predict the future. Machine learning models could highlight inefficiencies we couldn't see. Chatbots could handle thousands of customer queries in real time. Algorithms could identify which markets were ripest for expansion.

However, the challenge was never the technology, it was the mindset. Many seasoned managers resisted change, not because they didn't understand the technology, but because they feared it would make their roles obsolete. That fear is misplaced. AI cannot replace leadership. It cannot inspire a team during tough times. It cannot resolve conflicts rooted in emotion. It cannot replace the human touch in negotiations or the gut feeling that tells you something is off despite what the numbers say.

Preparing for the Future

As a leader, your responsibility is to be curious, not necessarily technical. You don't need to be a data scientist, but you do need to ask the right questions:

- What data are we not using today that could improve our decision-making?
- How can automation free up my team to focus on higher-value work?
- Where can predictive analytics help us anticipate change instead of reacting to it?

The most powerful trait in the age of AI is not technical mastery, it's adaptability. The ability to lead people through uncertainty. The humility to learn from tools that may know more than you. And the wisdom to know when not to rely solely on a machine's recommendation.

Leadership Lessons for the AI Age

- Lead with humanity: AI is powerful, but people still follow leaders, not algorithms. Empathy remains non-negotiable.
- Be data-informed, not data-blind: Let AI guide you, but don't let it replace your judgment.
- Champion lifelong learning: Encourage yourself and your teams to understand the basics of AI and data analytics. You don't need to know how it works, just what it can do.
- Use AI to elevate people, not replace them: Great leaders use technology to unlock their teams' potential, not to diminish it.

"AI will not replace managers. But managers who use AI will replace those who don't." ~ Adapted from Andrew Ng

As I look back on my journey from apprentice to Managing Director, I see leadership not as a destination, but as a constant evolution. The leaders of tomorrow will be those who embrace change, not just in markets and products, but in mindset and method. AI is not a threat, it's a tool. The question is: will you be the one wielding it, or the one being replaced by those who do?

The Digital Edge in Leadership

When I sit back now as a managing director, it's almost surreal to recall how bewildered I was by the idea of artificial intelligence early in my career. Back then, spreadsheets and email were cutting-edge; anything resembling "AI" felt like science fiction. Yet, the tide of technology has swept through the boardroom. Today's leaders are inundated with data and decisions, in fact, research shows that 85% of executives report "decision stress," with the volume of decisions exploding in recent years.

I've learned that AI isn't magic, but a powerful tool to help manage that pressure.

Looking back, I see how reluctant I once was and how embracing AI became pivotal in my own leadership journey.

*The future is going to
demand more tech
literacy than ever before.*

From Doubt to Discovery

In those early years, I trusted my gut more than any computer. I prided myself on intuition and personal judgment. When a colleague first mentioned machine learning or a “data-driven strategy,” I shrugged it off. It reminded me of an old anecdote: in the late 1990s, even competent business owners dismissed the Internet as a fad, vowing “I’m never getting on the Internet”

. We all know what happened – those who held out lost out. In my case, I nearly repeated that mistake with AI. I’ll admit it: I was skeptical and uneasy about “black box” algorithms making decisions. But slowly, real-world pressures forced me to question that skepticism. My turning point came when our company’s data started choking on itself. Sales figures, customer info, and forecasts were scattered across disconnected systems. I remember grappling with fragmented, unreliable data and slow, error-prone reports – just like the manager at Sparex who described “fragmented data” and “inefficient reporting”

. Inevitably, we hit a bottleneck in a budget review: I could see only smoke through the fog. That crisis drove me to explore analytics tools. To my surprise, what I found was liberating. We implemented a business intelligence platform that consolidated our data, giving us a single source of truth. Overnight, our dull spreadsheets transformed into dynamic dashboards. I saw colleagues light up as they ran their own analyses. It echoed what one industry expert said: data, when harnessed effectively, is “the lifeblood of modern organizations,” empowering better decisions and innovation.

It was a lesson in humility, my intuition was valuable, but it needed the guidance of clean, analyzed data.

Embracing the Algorithm

With momentum on our side, I began applying more AI-driven tools to routine problems. For example, forecasting became a collaboration between human insight and machine learning. We rolled out a predictive analytics model for inventory management. Before, I would rely on past experience and gut feelings to estimate demand. Now, I could plug in up-to-date variables and watch the model churn out projections with confidence intervals. The result? Fewer stockouts, smoother production planning, and a clear sense of what was driving demand. Colleagues who once resisted began to trust the numbers.

We essentially consolidated our disparate databases into one platform, much like Sparex did, and that “enabled real-time insights and predictive analytics” to accelerate decision-making. I still remember thinking, So this is what faster, smarter decisions feel like. Even mundane tasks got easier. I started using AI to automate repetitive work: scheduling meetings, drafting summary emails, or generating basic reports. What used to take hours of manual effort became almost instantaneous.

This freed our team to focus on strategy and people, rather than data entry. A benchmark research I saw years later crystallized why I felt so motivated to adapt: data-driven organizations are three times more likely to report significant improvements in decision-making than others.

In hindsight, turning to data wasn’t just a fad, it was a necessity. It was sobering to realize I had been trying to play on an uneven field, relying only on instinct while competitors used data like a secret weapon.

Lessons Learned and Advice

Looking back on that phase of my career, a few lessons stand out. First, I learned never to dismiss new tools out of hand. If anything, I became a little paranoid about being a “have-not.” One analyst’s words still ring in my ear: “The new haves and have-nots are going to be businesses that embraced AI and those that didn’t... if you’re not on the train, it’s distancing itself from you every single day”.

That turned out to be true in our industry. By the time I became director, surveys found that nearly 78% of companies already used AI in some form. We had joined the 22% or so left behind. I didn’t want my company to be the one caught off-guard as competitors sprinted ahead. Another big lesson was balance: AI is a tool, not a replacement for leadership. There’s a quote I came across about data and intuition saying the best decisions combine both. I live by that now. I learned to use AI outputs as powerful input, but then apply judgment, context, and values. For instance, an algorithm might flag customer churn risk, but I know my best team members and their customers, and that human touch matters too. So I’d take the AI’s analysis and then use my people skills to turn it into action.

This resonates with what data experts advise: use data for speed and accuracy, but maintain the human element in decision-making. In fact, one perspective even notes that leaders buried under data should sometimes trust a seasoned gut feeling. I found that truth again in my journey – AI amplified my effectiveness, but it never replaced the necessity of understanding my team and clients. To any aspiring manager reading this, my advice is clear: become comfortable with data and AI early. Don’t wait until you’re pushed. Start small if you must – use a simple analytics tool or experiment with an AI-powered assistant. I was heartened to learn that over half of top executives already use generative AI regularly. In other words, the people running businesses today expect their leaders to know this stuff. Cultivate a data-driven mindset: question decisions with “What does the data say?” and encourage your team to back arguments with evidence. At the same time, don’t let fear shut you down.

Change can be scary, but the true risk is stagnation. Remember that even storied managers of the past had to adopt new methods; the wise ones did, and the others faded away. Finally, use AI to empower your people rather than to control them. In my own transition, I consciously put my team at the center, teaching them how to use the new tools and encouraging feedback. I learned that adopting AI is as much a cultural change as a technical one. You need to build trust around it. When questions of “I don’t understand this model” or “Is the AI making all decisions?” arose, I made sure to explain and demystify. Over time, I saw creativity flourish once the routine burden was lifted.

My team began brainstorming even bigger improvements, no longer bogged down by manual work. This collaborative approach paid dividends.

***Artificial intelligence is
not a substitute for
human intelligence, it is
a tool to amplify human
creativity and ingenuity.***

Looking Ahead

Now, as I reflect on rising from apprentice to managing director, I see the role of AI as part of a broader leadership arc. Embracing AI tools was like learning a new language – initially awkward, but ultimately giving my leadership voice more reach. It sharpened my vision and freed me to focus on the human side of management: inspiring people, setting goals, and crafting strategy.

In the grand scheme, technology changes, and tools will evolve again, but the core of leadership remains constant. The best leaders remain curious, open to learning, and ready to integrate whatever helps their team excel. In the end, the journey taught me that data and AI are not just technical topics but reflections of good leadership values: courage to change, humility to learn, and wisdom to blend insight with intuition. Just as I once mentored junior colleagues in their early careers, I now mentor others in embracing AI. I tell them that AI is a powerful compass, but a compass needs a steady hand at the helm.

As long as managers remember to couple high-tech tools with high-touch leadership, they'll not only survive the digital revolution – they'll lead it.

Conclusion / Summary

“It was a great honor for me to write this book about my career.”

I really hope that the message of this book came clearly to young people out there and that they will realize that all things are possible if you focus and put your mind to it, but with lots of hard work.

It is clear in this book that humble and poor beginnings should not deter what you can achieve in life. God made you unique (only one like you) to achieve the goals that you have set.

It is also clear that networking and learning during your career will benefit you later. Understand that the “No pain no Gain” slogan applies but in the end, you will reap the benefits.

It must be clearly understood that optimizing your studies is of significant importance. School graduation opens a door, and a diploma opens another few, but your degree or additional achievements will open many doors for you to choose from.

Remember study whilst you are young, it is a once-off period, but it comes with benefits for a lifetime, and it promotes you to a higher earnings level. The statistics show it clearly.

By achieving your goals other doors i.e. Overseas trips will be possible which takes you into a new world of learning.

The stability of your family life is an integral part of your development and success. If it was not for my wife and lovely children I would not have achieved, what I did.

Today I not only have my Wife and children, but 9 Grand Children and soon 3 Great Grand Children. What a blessing and honor!

I worked for many companies in my career especially later due to short contract work. However, the experience that I have gained via all these companies boosted my general knowledge tremendously which I could apply in any Company. I cannot over emphasize the importance of adopting the Management style of “Trust and Inspire”. The old style of Command and Control is no longer appropriate in Business today. People must be free to develop and add value to businesses.

Don't fall into the trap of “poor management” as described in this book.

Don't be afraid to make mistakes as that is how you fail forward and make progress.

I was truly fortunate to have the unique moments in my life as described.

Take note of the section on Business and Life's learnings and apply these suggestions.

Finally, I wrote this book while being supported by my wife. This book is dedicated to my children and grandchildren. I hope that they will apply this in their future careers.

Last, but definitely not least the role that my parents and siblings played in my journey.

Testimonials

“Phil De Jager is an enthusiastic and results driven leader that focuses on continuous improvement in plants through People, Process & Technology. His extensive manufacturing experience enables him to rapidly identify improvement opportunities and put effective projects in place to deliver benefits in local and international companies ranging from Pharmaceuticals to various FMCG businesses.

Phil has acted in various operational leadership roles, including at Director level during his extensive career. He has a track record of transforming operations thereby contributing to business transformation from a service level improvement and cost reduction perspective.

His areas of experience and expertise include:

- ***Risk Management***
- ***People engagement and development***
- ***World-class manufacturing***
- ***Quality Improvement. FSSC accreditations***
- ***GMP improvement (Application of 5S principles)***
- ***Overall Equipment efficiencies***
- ***Manufacturing cost reduction***
- ***Planned maintenance practices***
- ***Capacity assessment and elimination of bottlenecks***
- ***Union engagements.***

Phil has proven to be an asset to the organisations that he has engaged with.”

~ Operations Executive - Tiger Brands - South Africa

“I’ve had the pleasure of working closely with Phil, during our time together at Futurelife. He added immense value at a time when we were looking for someone to bring structure and proven ‘know how’. If you are needing a person to bring leadership and process to set your supply chain up for experience, then Phil is your guy.

Phil’s depth of experience in manufacturing operations is truly exceptional. He brings a strategic mindset, hands-on expertise, and an unwavering ‘can-do’ attitude to every challenge. Whether it’s optimizing processes, improving efficiency, or driving cost savings, he has a remarkable ability to turn complex problems into practical, effective solutions.

His ownership, network, industry knowledge, and commitment to excellence make him an invaluable asset to any business looking to elevate its operations.

I will always look back fondly on the Kaizen, and Poka-Yoke lessons and principles you brought into our supply chain with your continuous improvement mindset. I highly recommend Phil for any consulting engagement—he will deliver results!”

~ General Manager - Futurelife South Africa

It is with pleasure that I endorse Phil De Jager for his future endeavours as a consultant in the manufacturing and supply chain industry. Having had the privilege of working with Phil during the integration period of our Futurelife business into PepsiCo ecosystem, I can confidently attest to his experience, leadership skills on the ground, and commitment to continued improvement in operations.

Throughout his tenure with our company, Phil demonstrated impactful leadership thanks to his hands-on approach and helped the team deliver improvements in the areas of Health & Safety, Food Safety, and overall Performance. He possesses a wealth of industry knowledge, a can-do attitude, and a strong ability to identify opportunities for operational efficiencies. He is an open-minded problem-solver with a results-driven mindset whose expertise will surely benefit organizations seeking to optimise their manufacturing processes and facilities.

I do recommend Phil as a consultant and am confident that any company seeking to improve their operational standards will find great value in his insights and expertise.

*~ Supply Chain Sr Director - Technical Services
PepsiCo South Africa*



Phil De Jager

Business Transformation Specialist



📞 076 084 3010 ✉️ phil@pdj-consulting.com 🌐 www.pdj-consulting.com